

9.1 Global village

(<http://smallworld.columbia.edu>)

They say it's a small world, and the Small World project (<http://smallworld.columbia.edu/>) aims to prove it statistically. It is an online experiment by sociologists at Columbia University which aims to validate the theory that people are at the most separated from one another by six degrees of separation. This experiment is actually like a controlled chain letter where you have to contact a specific target person through e-mail.

The thing works like this: You go to their site and log in using your e-mail id and a password. After agreeing to the terms and conditions of the project you are presented your target person. Your aim is to contact that person through friends who live closer to the target than you. After your friend gets your e-mail there would be two options. If your contact knows the target then the chain ends and the result would be one degree of separation. But if the target is unknown (which is more often the case), your contact would forward the mail to a person whose location is even closer. And thus the chain continues.



Details of your target appear after you log in

Now what makes this networking site different from most others is that you cannot directly contact unknown people. Sure, your target is not known to you but you have to contact him/her through acquaintances. This provision takes care of privacy concerns. As e-mails are sent through the Web site only, they are not